



Child Safeguarding Policy



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1.INTRODUCTION

Life Helpers Initiative, a non-government organization has a programmatic mandate towards children. This is enshrined in our programs which involve vulnerable children and the girl child as well as child protection. The core of this policy is child safeguarding. And according to the Nigerian constitution which Life Helpers shall abide by, a child is defined as anyone under 18 years of age, irrespective of creed, tribe or religion.

With the vision, 'A more fulfilled life for everybody, and a mission statement, 'To be a leading non-governmental organization working to maximize all opportunities to empower the marginalized people

We like to acknowledge the role of Save the Children International and the team of the Organizational Development Unit [OD] of the System Transformed for Empowered Action and Enabled Response for Vulnerable Children and Households for their support in developing this policy as well as Save the Children UK who provided us with the framework policy document to adapt and adopt as well as other organisations that has contributed to the reviews.

Objectives of this document

The objective of this policy and principles is to enumerate clear responsibilities that ensure all staff, operations and programs do no harm to children, that is that they do not expose children to the risk of harm and abuse and that any concerns the organization has about children's safety within the communities in which they work are reported to the appropriate authorities.

Scope of this document

This policy covers anybody who represents Life Helpers. This means that all the following people must implement the policy and adhere to its requirements: all staff – whether permanent, project, or Volunteer/interns, contractors, as well as all trustees, stakeholders and board members.

2. Vulnerable Persons Covered by the Policy

01 Child Protection and Rights Policy Statement

- All children and young people below the age of eighteen years should be protected from all forms of abuse, neglect, exploitation and violence and adheres to the fundamental rights of the child as spelt out in the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child of 1989.

02 Safeguarding Vulnerable Adults Policy

- Vulnerable adults, persons over the age of eighteen years who are unable to take care of or protect themselves against harm or exploitation for whatever reason, require particular protection.

03 Rights and Dignity of Vulnerable Persons

- Both children and vulnerable adults (hereinafter referred to as the "Vulnerable Persons") have rights as individuals and shall be treated with dignity and respect.

3. Definition



Safeguarding means taking reasonable steps to prevent harm particularly sexual exploitation, abuse and harassment from occurring to protect people especially children and vulnerable adults from harm and to respond appropriately when harm does occur.

Types of Child Safeguarding Concerns

Physical Abuse: Any harm to a child's body (e.g. beating, injury, forcing harmful tasks).

Emotional Abuse: Harm to a child's mental wellbeing (e.g. insults, humiliation, threats).

Sexual Abuse & Exploitation (PSEA): Any sexual activity with a child or exchange of benefits for sex. A child cannot give consent..

Neglect: Failure to provide basic care (e.g. food, supervision, medical care).

Child Labour / Exploitation: Using children for work or personal gain.

Discrimination: Unfair treatment based on gender, disability, or background.

Digital Safeguarding Risks: Online harm (Posting children's photos without consent Sharing personal information Online exploitation).

Bullying: Repeated behavior that harms, intimidates, or pressures a child. (Examples: teasing, insults, threats, exclusion, forcing a child to do something.)

Harassment: Any unwanted behavior that makes a child feel uncomfortable, unsafe, or afraid.
(Examples abusive language, inappropriate comments, unwanted attention (including sexual harassment)).

4. Safeguarding Principles



Life Helpers Initiative is commits to:



DO NOT HARM

Activities must not expose beneficiaries to risk



BEST INTEREST OF THE CHILD:

All decisions prioritize child welfare



ZERO TOLERANCE:

No form of abuse or exploitation is tolerated



NON-DISCRIMINATION:

Equal protection for all



CONFIDENTIALITY:

Information shared on a need-to-know basis



ACCOUNTABILITY:

All concerns must be reported and acted upon

Safeguarding Principles

WELLBEING.

The protection of children from all forms of violence is both a corporate and individual responsibility. Everyone who works for LHI (including all those affiliated with the organization: staff members, contractors, interns, volunteers, board members...) must take all possible precautions to protect the children with whom they come into direct or indirect contact with

This also means holding ourselves to account in ensuring that no child or young person is harmed or placed at risk of harm as a result of their association with us, and ensuring that where applicable clear measures are put in place for national sections working with partners (assessment, agreement, support, capacity-building and monitoring and evaluation).

We understand that all staff should be trained in child safeguarding and that child protection focal points should receive extra training to enable them to fulfil their role.

We have a responsibility to care for and protect children and young people, especially those that are vulnerable, and make sure they are not harmed.

We have responsibilities towards children and young people with whom we come into contact. No child or young person must suffer harm, intentionally or unintentionally, as a result of their engagement, association or contact with us whether as a sponsored child, a participant in our programs, projects, events.

We have a responsibility to inform and empower children and young people so that they learn about and are better able to exercise their rights to protection. We will work with children and young people ensuring they understand the essence of this policy, our safeguarding commitment and the means via which they can report policy breaches.

We promote child and youth safe practices, approaches, interventions and environments which respect, recognize and respond to the specific safeguarding needs and addresses the protection risks of the differing gender and other identities.

Safeguarding Principles

We will challenge and do not tolerate inequality, discrimination or exclusion. We respond to a child or young person who may need protection and or psycho-social support and intend that their welfare and best interests will at all times be paramount consideration.

We shall ensure that all we work with and engage with us understand and are supported in their meeting safeguarding roles and responsibilities. We take positive action to prevent anyone who might be a risk to children and young people from becoming involved with us and take stringent measures against any Staff, Associate or Visitor who perpetrates an act of violence against a child.

We will act on safeguarding concerns, ensuring that our actions are apt, appropriate and positioned around the child or young person, taking into consideration their gender and other specific safeguarding needs and vulnerabilities

We will work together in partnership with other agencies to promote the safeguarding of children and young people within organizations engaged with us and in the wider community. Investigated in accordance with disciplinary procedures and contractual agreements, or a referral may be made to statutory authorities for criminal investigation under the law of the country in which they work.

Breaches may incur sanctions including disciplinary action leading to possible dismissal, termination of all relations including contractual and partnership agreements, and where relevant, appropriate legal or other such actions.



5 Basic Requirements & Rules



The following people must comply with this Child Safeguarding Policy:

01

All staff, full-time, part-time, volunteers in any location, and to those engaged on short-term contracts, e.g., consultants, researchers etc.;

02

staff and representatives of partner agencies and any other individuals, groups or organizations who have a formal/contractual relationship with Life Helpers that involves them having contact with children – unless it has been agreed under the national guidance and local procedures that the partner organization may enforce its own safeguarding or protection policy.

03

All Life Helpers staff and representatives must act in accordance with this policy in both their professional and their personal lives.

04

Board members, trustees;

05

Donors, journalists, celebrities, politicians and other people who visit Life Helpers programs or offices and may come into contact with children must be briefed of this policy and be made aware that they must act in accordance with it while visiting our offices or participating in any activity.

06

All Life Helpers staff and representatives must know that as they attest to or accept their Appointment letter; they are under the obligation to meet the requirement of this policy, the Child Safeguarding, read and understand its procedures and will act in accordance with these documents.

5 Basic Requirements & Rules



All staff and representatives must:

- Report concernsthat a child is a survivor of child abuse or sexualexploitation immediately in accordance with their Local Procedures.
- Undertake inductionand training on thispolicy which is relevant and appropriate to their position.
- Cooperate fully and confidentially in any investigation of concerns and allegations.
- Respond to a child who may have been abused/exploited in accordance with the Local Procedures and in accordance with their best interest and safety.
- Identify minimizeand attempt to avoid potential situations of risk for children
- Identify and avoid potential situations, which may lead tostaff behaviors being misinterpreted
- Ensure, when making images of children e.g., photographs, and videos, that they are respectful, that the children are adequately clothed and that sexually suggestive poses are avoided;
- Ensure that any image or recorded case history of a child does not place him/her at risk or render him/her vulnerable to any form of abuse.
- Ensure that the Child Safeguarding – Safe Child Participation policy is complied with if any child is to participate in any activity other than as a beneficiary, e.g. a campaigning event, awards ceremony, panel or any other event or in internet social networking

Life Helpers staff and representatives must never:



- Hit or otherwise physically assault or physically abuse children;
- Have sexual intercourse, or engage in any sexual activity, with anyone under 18 years of age, regardless of the age of consent locally. Mistaken belief in the age of the child is not a defense; Develop relationships with children which could in any way be deemed exploitative or abusive;
- Act in ways that may be abusive or may place a child at risk of abuse;
- Use language, make suggestions or offer advice which is inappropriate, offensive or abusive;
- Behave physically in a way that is inappropriate or sexually provocative;
- Have a child/child with whom they are working to stay overnight at their home (unless necessary and previously agreed with management that this is for the safety of the child);
- Sleep in the same bed as a child with whom they are working without consent, permission or justifiable reasons;
- Do things for children of an intimate, personal nature that they can do for themselves;
- Condone, or participate in, behaviours of children which is illegal, unsafe or abusive;
- Act in ways intended to shame, humiliate, belittle or degrade children, or otherwise perpetrate any form of emotional abuse;
- Discriminate against, show unfair differential treatment to, or favor particular children to the exclusion of others;
- Act as a negotiator in or assist the process of the financial settlement between the family of a child victim of sexual abuse or exploitation and the perpetrator; or
- Spend excessive time alone with children away from others (including in vehicles) or spend time in a child's home unless exceptional circumstances apply and has prior approval of the line manager.

Life Helpers staff and representatives must:



All staff and representatives must be aware that any allegation of the abuse or exploitation of children made against them will be investigated, under these Child Safeguarding policies

- By consideration of referral to statutory authorities for criminal investigation and prosecution under the law of the country in which they work (this also applies to any representative or staff of any partner agency with whom Life Helpers has agreed child protection protocols); and/or
- By Life Helpers in accordance with the Global, National and Local Procedures for dealing with Suspected Abuse and Exploitation and under disciplinary procedures, this may result in dismissal.

All agreements between Life Helpers and implementing partners, other individuals, groups or organizations who have a formal/contractual relationship to Life Helpers that involves them having contact with children must include agreement on the issue of this Child Safeguarding Policy.

Partner agencies must adopt this policy or have developed their own policy of a similar standard. Partnership agreements must clearly outline agreed procedures for reporting and investigating concerns involving breaches of the policy involving issues of child abuse and exploitation

7. Guidance

- Life Helpers Initiative has a central commitment to child safeguarding.
- Safeguarding children is a global responsibility. Within this broad approach there are specific responsibilities within departments and positions. This is reflected in the structure of these policies. This Child Safeguarding policy should be seen as the universal set of responsibilities, the implementation of which is enabled through the direct supervision of the Gender Focal/Child Protection Officer
- All staff and representatives should recognize that:
 - all children are equal irrespective of their gender, disability, ethnicity, sexuality, marital status or religion.
 - all children have the right to freedom from abuse and exploitation;
 - all child abuse involves the abuse of children's rights;
- Life Helper's commitment to children's rights means that we have the commitment to safeguard children, especially those we are in contact with;
- Life Helpers is committed to ensuring that children are aware of their right to be protected from abuse and exploitation and we will communicate that right to them; and
- Life Helpers is committed to ensuring that all our own staff and representatives wherever they are located, apply the highest standards of behaviour towards children both within their professional and their private lives
- All staff and representatives should
 - plan and organize the work and the workplace so as to minimize risk of abuse, exploitation or harm coming to a child;
 - promote a culture of openness in relation to child safeguarding issues, where any issues or concerns can be raised and discussed;
 - ensure that a sense of accountability exists between staff so that poor practice or potentially abusive behaviour can be challenged;
 - talk to children about their contact with staff or others and encourage them to raise any concerns;
 - empower child beneficiaries and communicate to them their rights, what is acceptable and unacceptable, and what they can do if there is a problem;

7. Guidance

- communicate to child beneficiaries what standards of professional practice they can expect of Life Helpers staff and what to do if they feel that Life Helpers staff are falling short of these standards; and
- Proactively seek opposition to safeguard children and principles and procedures to guide staff in responding to cases of suspected abuse.
- There are Local Procedures drawn up in the country and they provide practical procedures for when and how to report concerns of abuses. These local procedures will be identified and followed when there is a need to report issues that occur in child abuses/exploitation.
- Adhering to these Policies, Procedures and Guidance will safeguard children from abuse, ensure concerns are addressed professionally, and may safeguard staff and representatives from allegations of misconduct or abuse.
- By following this policy, staff and representatives will both be playing their part in safeguarding children and developing best practices in working with children. As with the general Code of Conduct, if a staff member breaks this policy or fails to meet the standard of behaviours that it requires, disciplinary action may be taken. This may include dismissal and/or referral to national authorities for criminal investigation and prosecution.
- Things of an intimate, personal nature: This includes activities of an intimate nature such as toileting, bathing and dressing a child. These activities should only be undertaken if the child is unable to do them him/herself.
- Guidance on good practice in this area is available and the SGF/CPO officer can be contacted for further and specific clarification.

8. Reporting



Reporting (First)

All safeguarding concerns must be reported through:

- Safeguarding Officer
- Supervisor or Line Manager
- Suggestion boxes
- Toll-free hotline
- Email reporting channel

Key Reporting Principles:

- Report immediately (within 48 hours)
- Maintain confidentiality
- No retaliation for reporting
- Email reporting channel

Safeguarding Reporting Flow

Concern Identified



Report to Safeguarding Officer



Immediate Risk Assessment



Investigation Initiated



Decision & Action Taken



8. Response and Case Management

LHI will ensure:

Immediate safety of survivor

- Confidential and survivor-centered response
- Referral to appropriate services (health, legal, psychosocial)
- Proper documentation of all actions
- Follow-up and case closure



9 . Disciplinary Measures

Violations of this policy will result in:

- Verbal warning for minor misconduct
- Written warning for repeated or moderate violations
- Suspension (with or without pay) pending investigation
- Termination of employment or contract for serious violations
- Blacklisting from future engagement with the organization
- Referral to law enforcement agencies where criminal acts are involved

All disciplinary measures will follow due process, ensuring fairness, confidentiality, and survivor-centered approaches



Disciplinary committee (safeguarding) LHI

A. Composition of the Committee (LHI Specific)

The Disciplinary Committee at Life Helpers Initiative (LHI) shall be constituted as follows:

Position (LHI)

S/N	POSITION (LHI)	ROLE
1	Executive Director Chairperson	Provides overall leadership and final oversight on decisions
2	Safeguarding Director	Presents investigation findings and ensures safeguarding compliance
3	Human Resource Officer	Guides disciplinary procedures in line with HR policy
4	Program Manager	Provides program-level context and operational insights
5	Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E) Officer	Supports documentation, evidence review, and data integrity
6	Legal Adviser (if available)	Provides legal guidance where necessary
7	Director Audit	Review whether procedures were: · Properly followed · Well documented · Free from bias or irregularities

B. Additional Guidance for LHI Structure

- Where the Executive Director is unavailable, a Senior Management Staff may serve as Chairperson.
- At least one female member must be part of the committee to ensure gender sensitivity.
- Members must have no direct involvement in the case under review.

Disciplinary committee (safeguarding) LHI

C. Approval Structure

All disciplinary decisions shall:

- Be reviewed and endorsed by the Executive Director
- Be communicated officially through the Human Resource Unit
- Be documented and stored securely by the Safeguarding Officer

The following are key steps in any process to substantiate any reported allegations:

a. Investigate

The Safeguarding director will consult with the executive director as appropriate. The allegation will be investigated and the individual(s) concerned informed of the allegations against him or her, and the course of action to be taken. At the same time, the Safeguarding Officer will ensure that all information in the possession of the individual suspected is secured for investigation. If appropriate to safeguard Life Helper during the investigation period, the individual alleged to have committed the abuse may be taken out of his/her position. This may mean the individual is put into another position, put on leave with pay or suspended without pay.

b. Collect evidence

Depending on the magnitude and complexity of the offence, investigations will be carried out by the head office. The involvement of external parties must be approved by the Safeguarding Director.

c. Report

Ensuring a report is issued on a timely basis detailing the findings and conclusions of the investigation including recommendations for action to be taken. The report will only be disclosed to the Executive Director and Board, and others with a need to know. This is important to avoid damaging the reputation of those suspected of wrongdoing and subsequently found innocent.

d. Action

In all cases, the course of action will be determined in consultation with the relevant Director and executive Director

10 . Prevention Measures

Safeguarding in training and program implementation

1. Safeguarding During Training Activities

Life Helpers Initiative (LHI) is committed to ensuring that all training and program activities are conducted in a safe, inclusive, and protective environment for all participants.

To support this:

- Training environments will be safe, accessible, and inclusive, especially for women, children, and vulnerable groups.
- Special consideration will be given to breastfeeding mothers, including:
- Provision of a safe, private, and comfortable space for breastfeeding
- Where feasible, provision of support for childcare (e.g., nanny/childcare support) during training sessions
- Training schedules will be designed to be flexible and responsive to the needs of participants, particularly caregivers.
- All facilitators and staff will be required to adhere to safeguarding principles and code of conduct during trainings.

2. Safeguarding Mainstreaming in Project Design and Budgeting

LHI will ensure that safeguarding is fully integrated into all project planning, implementation, and budgeting processes.

This includes:

- Inclusion of safeguarding training for staff, volunteers, and partners in all projects
- Allocation of dedicated budget lines for safeguarding activities, including:
- Safeguarding training and capacity building
- Community awareness and IEC materials
- Feedback and reporting mechanisms (e.g., hotline, suggestion boxes)
- Child protection and survivor support services
- Conducting risk assessments for all activities to identify and mitigate safeguarding risks
- Ensuring monitoring and reporting on safeguarding compliance throughout the project lifecycle

3. Commitment

LHI recognizes that safeguarding is not optional but a core programmatic requirement, and therefore commits to ensuring that all interventions are safe, inclusive, and protective by design.

Members of the Board are responsible for:

- Ensuring adequate measures are in place to assess and address safeguarding risks.
- Putting in place adequate safeguarding policies and procedures, including relevant HR matters.
- Making sure policies and procedures are effectively applied in practice and that mechanisms are in place
- to provide assurance of compliance.
- Ensuring those safeguarding policies, practices, and performance are robustly and regularly reviewed to ensure they are up to date and fit for purpose.
- Actively promoting a safe culture and strong awareness of everyone's safeguarding responsibilities

11. Monitoring and Compliance

- Regular safeguarding audits
- Supervision and reporting systems
- Feedback mechanisms
- Periodic policy review(2 Years)



12. Incident Reporting Form (Sample)

- Date of Report: _____
- Name of Reporter: _____
- Location: _____
- Type of Incident: _____
- Description: _____
- Persons Involved: _____
- Immediate Action Taken: _____
- Reported to: _____
- Follow-up Required: _____
- Life helper's legal staff.



13. Safeguarding Checklist (Sample)

- ☐ Staff trained on safeguarding
- ☐ Reporting channels available
- ☐ Policy shared with community
- ☐ Risk assessment conducted
- ☐ Cases documented properly



14. Approval and Commitment

This policy is approved by the Board of Trustees and is mandatory for all staff and partners.

- Name:_____
- Position:_____
- Signature:_____
- Date: _____
- Conclusion

LHI is committed to ensuring that all individuals, especially children and vulnerable persons, are protected from harm and treated with dignity, respect, and care at all times.

